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INDIA AND JAPAN'S GRAND BARGAIN IN THE CONTEXT OF CHINA'S RISE

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Introduction

Between 11 and 13 May 1998, India detonated five nuclear bombs at Pokhran in the Thar Desert in Western India. For many in India and around the world, this act announced India's arrival on the world stage – a crossing of the Rubicon, as it were – in addition to guaranteeing India's security relative to its two principal rivals, Pakistan and China.[1] For Japan, however, India's tests represented "an intolerable challenge to international society."[2] Tokyo immediately reacted by freezing Yen-loans to India, temporarily recalling its ambassador from New Delhi, and initiating efforts to bring multilateral pressure to bear on India through international financial institutions and the G8.[3] The Japanese Prime Minister, Ryutaro Hashimoto, went so far as to try and place the Kashmir issue on the agenda of the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) – a potentially major blow for Indian interests – in a bid to restrain Pakistan